

Read the product descriptions carefully

With stricter and more streamlined buyer protection laws, online stores in the US are bound to disclose all details pertinent to the product. However, with long descriptions and the excitement of having spotted a great deal, buyers tend to ignore the details. For example, a product that is categorised as “new” can have another tag that says, “Open Box”. These products are not used but they aren’t exactly brand new, un-touched items. They might have been used for demo purposes or returned the very next day by the customer. So, such products can be up for sale at a much lower price but you ought to be clear about what you’re buying. In case of products like laptops, there might be multiple configurations for the same model listed across the store, for instance, the Lenovo Thinkpad 410s has several configurations listed on the eBay Global Easy Buy site, and unless you read the description in detail, you might end up buying the ₹65,000 config as the best deal, not realising that it has a regular mechanical hard drive instead of the 128GB SSD in all other configs, which are priced just ₹5,000 higher than the cheapest one.

Shipping can make or break a deal

While browsing through ShopYourWorld.com, I was mighty tempted to order a set of bookshelf speakers, a pair of Wharfedale Diamond 9.1 was listed under ₹8,000 – sweet! However, after adding the shipping charges, the total cost shipped to my doorstep climbed to almost ₹16,000. Lesson learnt! Ordering heavy stuff can really hike up your budget and the added tension of physical damage to the goods always lingers in the back of your mind.



Shipping rates are also pretty tricky, once a product crosses 5 pounds (2.27kgs); the shipping rates almost doubles. So, it’s not just the duties that can sour the deal. Shipping charges can be a deal breaker too, so it’s advisable to watch the weight.

Custom duties for electronic goods imported into India and exemption criterion*

Laptop/Computers /Tablets.....	14.712 %
DVD/ CDS (movie)	26.849 %
Other than Movie CD/DVD	14.712 %
Mobiles.....	1.030 %
Digital / Video Cameras	26.849 %
Digital Still Image Camera.....	14.712 %
Sports equipment	14.712 %
Entertainment, Sports equipment, Video games	26.849 %
Electronics and Car parts.....	26.849 %
Computer Printers	14.712 %
Wrist Watches	26.849 %
iPod/ portable media players	26.849 %
DVD Players.....	26.849 %
Web cameras.....	26.849 %
Hard Disk (Internal)	4.000 %
Hard Disk (External)	14.712 %
Processor.....	4.000 %
Other computer peripherals.....	14.712 %
Gaming Consoles.....	27.000 %
Television	27.000 %

*You may import goods up to the value of ₹10,000 duty-free provided they’re sent as gifts to you. This value doesn’t include the shipping charges paid for getting that item into India. Since these exemptions are primarily based on the assumption of not making you pay for the gifts that you receive, the sender and the receiver of the gift can’t be the same party and should have unique residential addresses to avoid any sort of discrepancy.

Look for stuff that's impossible to get here

Camera lens adapters, iPad car kits, privacy filters for laptops, speaker stands for hi-fi speakers and similar products are hard to find in the Indian market and are priced exorbitantly due to a limited market appeal. Such objects are good candidates for importing through online sellers. Another possible scenario for buyers with deep pockets is buying products that are far away from launch in India or at times never make it to the Indian market. The latest Sony

NEX series, the NEX C3 and NEX 5N, for example, are fantastic little cameras with latest generation dSLR sensors. The Sony Alpha NEX 5N is available for purchase at shopyourworld.com for about ₹45,000. It sells for \$700 on Amazon.com which roughly comes to about ₹35,000.

What about warranty?

Warranty is important, and that’s where the entire “shop at international stores from the comfort of your home” can be a real bummer. Almost 100 per cent of the products you purchase online come with warranty, but these are valid only in the country from which they were purchased. So forget about getting local warranty. You have to ship the products back to the seller to claim warranty for the product and apart from the time frame of about 15-20 days, the cost of shipping must be borne by the buyer. A strong case for sticking to accessories and products that are least affected by warranty issues.

